DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Did Rabbi Yehudah HaNasi Suffer for 13 Years?

Daat Tevunot §170

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §170 (continued; section 9, part 3) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 26 October 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

Page 570, halfway through §170. We are discussing mazal, not in the sense of influence flowing through the heavenly bodies, which a Jew can override, but in the sense of the decree that sets a person in the world either to bring down shefa by receiving good, or through evil intensifying until the world looks chaotic.

We need both, which is why not all saddikim suffer. But then it seemed that anyone suffering must be a saddik. The answer was that there are two systems: mazal, and sekhar veonesh, reward and punishment as consequences of our deeds.

The two modes

The Ramhal restates: one mode is reward and punishment; the other has nothing to do with our actions and depends purely on God's decree. God uses each as He sees best for the world.

The Zohar: when God leaves both thrones

The Ramhal brings a Zohar that sounds strange unless you understand what we have learned. When God removes Himself from the throne of judgment and the throne of mercy, there is no reward and no punishment.

The Rabbi pointed out that it says both thrones. We learned before that there is the throne of din, strict justice, and the throne of rahamim, the "override button". But sometimes God removes Himself from both, and there is no reward and punishment at all in this world. Then the world is run only through mazal, and good and bad come according to what the general tikkun requires.

A participant objected: surely there is always reward and punishment. Yes, says the Ramhal, in olam haba there certainly is, and each person will receive according to his ways. The Zohar is speaking about this world.

The Zohar adds that as we approach the time of Mashiah, we should not be troubled if the righteous suffer greatly, if prayers seem unanswered, and if there is great brazenness in the world. To bring out the full revelation of the Yihud we need the chaos, and so however great you are, it will not help. Mazal will be the dominant mode at the end of times.

§170: the two modes work together

Now, in answer to the participant's question, the Ramhal adds something that explains many things. The two modes are not just separate. Even when God runs the world by mazal, He makes what must happen look as if it comes from reward and punishment. They are mixed together.

Rabbi Yehudah HaNasi

The Gemara tells that Rabbi Yehudah HaNasi, who was extremely wealthy, suffered for thirteen years. Why? Once an animal about to be slaughtered was in great fear, and he said to it: this is what you were created for. For this, says the Gemara, he suffered thirteen years.

Really? He was a little insensitive, and what he said was true. Thirteen years for that? The answer, said the Rabbi, is that the thirteen years came from the mode of mazal: he needed to suffer as a saddik for the sake of the tikkun. But God brought it in a way that looked like reward and punishment.

And the reverse: after thirteen years, he took care of a small creature, and his suffering ended. Thirteen years of suffering ending because he looked after a little animal? No: it was time for the mazal of his suffering to end, so God made it depend on a good deed he had done.

So God "rides" the mazal on top of a drop of reward and punishment. A completely righteous person may be suffering because of mazal, but there will be something very minor he did, which does not justify the suffering, yet allows people to say: look, this is the result.

Why disguise it? Because the mode of mazal is the hidden one, bringing the world to the tikkun haklali, and it works in a roundabout, concealed way. It looks like ordinary reward and punishment, but it rides on top of it.

The Ramhal's summary

The root of everything is the tikkun haklali, the final rectification in which God removes all deficiency. The revealed mode, reward and punishment, is apparent, and everything seems to depend on it. But within it is the movement towards the final rectification. They do not contradict each other. Rather, the main thing is the hidden mode, and reward and punishment is part of it: the mode of mazal comes about through the means of reward and punishment.

The Rabbi summed up: there are two modes; mazal can be good or bad; we never know which is operating; and more than that, they operate simultaneously. When mazal is decreed on a person, it comes about through what looks like reward and punishment, though exaggerated: thirteen years of suffering for something small, or great good for a minor deed. "This is really crucial to understand."

No one can say why

Finally, on page 576, a point "people are not careful about". God has hidden from human beings the ability to understand the mode of mazal, and also how it relates to reward and punishment. Even the prophets could not tell, except when they were told explicitly, for example that something was happening because Israel broke Shabbat or afflicted the orphan and the widow. Even Moshe did not know the answer.

So anyone who claims that a particular tragedy or blessing happened because of a particular thing is, in the Rabbi's words, "a liar, simple as that". We have no prophets today. You can speculate or suggest, but not state it. A participant asked whether one may at least say in a general way that suffering atones for sins. Very generally, said the Rabbi, but even that may not be true in a particular case.

One final part of section 9 remains, and then the Ramhal summarises the book before section 10.

Summary

- When God "leaves both thrones", this world runs only by mazal, according to the needs of the tikkun; reward and punishment remain certain in olam haba.
- Near the time of Mashiah, the righteous suffering and unanswered prayers should not shake us; the chaos is part of revealing the Yihud.
- The two modes work together: mazal is disguised as reward and punishment, as with Rabbi Yehudah HaNasi's thirteen years.
- The hidden mode is the main one, and reward and punishment is its vehicle.
- No one without explicit prophecy can say why a particular event happened.

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